bKash: a product teardown

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I have used bKash for more than eight years, so this teardown mixes that experience with public reporting. Sources are numbered in brackets and listed at the end. The suggestions are my own ideas, not company plans.

What it is

bKash is the biggest mobile money service in Bangladesh. It started in 2011 as a joint venture between BRAC Bank and Money in Motion, and BRAC Bank owns 51% today [2]. The company says it has more than 83 million customers, over 350,000 agents and around 900,000 merchants [1]. In the first quarter of 2026 it made Tk1,802 crore in net revenue, up 10%, and Tk184 crore in net profit, up 40% [2].

Who uses it and why

Most people who started using bKash had no bank account. They still needed to send money home, pay bills and top up phones, and an agent shop down the road could do all of that. That is the real product: a bank branch that fits inside any corner shop.

There are three groups to keep in mind. Individuals send money, cash in and out, and receive remittances; bKash says over Tk100 billion came in through it in 2024 [5]. Agents earn a small cut and have to keep enough cash on hand. Merchants take payments, and more of them now do it through Bangla QR, which bKash says has replaced the older codes at more than 800,000 merchants [6].

How it earns

Mostly fees. Cashing out costs Tk18.50 per Tk1,000, and sending money costs Tk5 [2]. On top of that it sells financial products through the same wallet. Partner banks opened more than 3.7 million DPS savings accounts via the app, and its small instant loans were used 3.3 million times [5]. It has also piloted nano loans for merchants with BRAC Bank, using their sales history instead of collateral [6].

Against the competition

Nagad and Rocket are the main rivals, but nobody agrees on how big bKash's lead is. Industry people say it holds over 60% of the market, while some official data put it nearer 45% [4]. An older dataset from December 2022 had it at 39.9%, with Nagad on 18.1% and Rocket on 11.7% [8]. Either way it is the biggest. What protects it is that users, agents and merchants all depend on each other, which is hard for a newcomer to copy. Experts have even discussed whether it should face "significant market power" rules [4].

What I have noticed as a long-time user

The thing that bothers me most is typing my PIN in public. Every time I confirm a transaction with people around me, I worry that someone standing close enough could see it. For an app that holds real money, that feels like a weak point.

bKash does offer fingerprint or face confirmation, but only for some transactions (send money, mobile recharge, payment and bill payment), and you have to switch it on yourself. It also only works on compatible phones [9][10]. I suspect many people never turn it on, so the PIN stays the habit. My view is that the safer option should be easier to find and should cover every transaction type.

Two smaller things I like: the in-app map that helps people find agents, merchants and ATMs nearby [7], and the speaker boxes at merchant counters that announce each payment out loud, so shopkeepers do not have to check a phone [6].

What works

Reach is the big one. There is an agent or merchant almost everywhere [1]. People also say the brand name as if it were the activity itself. And bKash is slowly adding savings, loans and QR payments on top of a base it already has [5][6].

What doesn't

Trust is the weak spot. A March 2026 report described a growing pile of complaints, and cited research finding that 6.3% of individual users and 17% of agents had run into fraud or disputes. Many people stop reporting problems [3]. Typing a PIN in public adds to that worry. Cash-out fees also make holding cash feel cheaper than using digital money [2]. And because bKash is treated as national infrastructure, regulators are watching it closely [4].

What I would change

1. Make fingerprint or face confirmation the default for every transaction. This comes straight from my own use. If the phone supports it, ask users to turn it on during their next transaction, and extend it beyond the four transaction types it covers today [9]. A PIN would remain as a fallback. To test it, prompt a random group of users to enable biometrics and compare opt-in rates and PIN-related complaints with a control group. The limits are real: the feature only works on handsets with a certain biometric class [10], so a PIN fallback has to stay, and bKash would need a way to handle people who change phones.

2. Show people where their complaint stands. Add a "report a problem" flow with a simple status: received, under review, resolved, plus a target time. I think trust is what matters most, and [3] suggests people give up when they cannot see any progress. To test it, show it to a random group of users and compare their complaint calls and repeat complaints with everyone else. The catch is that a visible deadline puts pressure on support, so the team needs to be ready first.

How I would measure it

For the biometric change, I would track how many people turn it on and what share of eligible transactions are confirmed by fingerprint or face, along with PIN-related complaints. For the complaint tracker, I would watch how long disputes take to resolve and how many close within the target. To make sure I wasn't hurting the product, I would also check how many people still hold a balance after 30 days.

Sources

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